

# Commander School Syllabus

## Officer Formation Level IV

**Course purpose.** Commander School forms the officer who can be trusted with senior command. It is the transition from regional steward to institutional guardian: a man who can preserve mission, align senior officers, direct the life of the Order below the Grandmaster, govern through clear doctrine and disciplined authority, and prepare the next generation of leaders without making the office about himself.

## Historical Foundation

The historical model for Commander School is drawn from the **Marshal** and the **Seneschal**. The Marshal was the Templars’ **highest-ranking military official** and the officer in charge of **war and anything related to it**. The Seneschal served as the Grand Master’s right-hand man, advisor, and administrative deputy. Together, these offices provide the clearest foundation for a Commander-level school focused on operational authority and executive stewardship.

## Course-Wide Learning Objectives

| Objective Area             | Course-Wide Objective                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Templar identity           | Explain how senior command functioned in the Templar Order and why top officers were essential to preserving mission, unity, and continuity.                          |
| Officer responsibility     | Describe the role of a Commander as the highest officer steward beneath the Grandmaster, charged with mission protection, senior alignment, and institutional health. |
| Leadership under authority | Demonstrate the ability to exercise broad authority while remaining fully aligned with the mission, law, and higher purpose of the Order.                             |
| Character formation        | Practice humility, disciplined speech, composure, justice, and sacrificial stewardship at the highest officer level.                                                  |
| Leader development         | Direct, evaluate, and strengthen majors, captains, and the wider officer pipeline through principled command and succession planning.                                 |
| Promotion readiness        | Show evidence of readiness for the highest officer office through institutional assessment, command judgment, senior leadership practicum, and final board review.    |

## 12-Lesson Syllabus Overview

| Lesson | Title                                         | Learning Objectives                                                                                                                                                                                             | Assignment                                                                                                                                    | Leadership Outcome                                                                 |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1      | The Burden of Senior Command                  | Define the purpose of Commander School; explain the shift from oversight of several bodies to stewardship of the whole Order below the Grandmaster; identify the responsibilities of a Commander in your Order. | 1-2 page reflection: "What changes when an officer becomes responsible for the mission and health of the whole body beneath the Grandmaster?" | Begins to think like an institutional steward rather than only a regional officer. |
| 2      | Senior Command in the Knights Templar         | Summarize how top Templar leadership functioned; explain the relationship among Grand Master, Seneschal, Marshal, and senior offices.                                                                           | Short presentation or visual summary on senior Templar command structure.                                                                     | Understands the historical model of high office.                                   |
| 3      | The Offices of Marshal and Seneschal          | Describe the duties of the Marshal and Seneschal; connect those duties to your Commander rank as the highest officer before Grandmaster.                                                                        | 2-page comparison: "The Templar Marshal/Seneschal and the modern Commander in our Order."                                                     | Sees Commander as a capstone office of both command and stewardship.               |
| 4      | Doctrine, Mission, and Institutional Identity | Explain how a Commander protects the Order's identity, mission, and standards across all levels; define the Commander's duty to guard what the Order is.                                                        | Draft a one-page institutional doctrine statement covering mission, standards, and command expectations.                                      | Understands how to preserve institutional clarity.                                 |
| 5      | Authority, Judgment, and Command Presence     | Learn the difference between holding office and carrying authority well; apply disciplined bearing, restraint, and visible steadiness to senior command.                                                        | Complete a command-presence self-assessment with mentor feedback and action plan.                                                             | Grows in gravity, composure, and responsible use of authority.                     |
| 6      |                                               | Learn how a Commander aligns majors, captains, and lieutenants under                                                                                                                                            | Build a senior-officer alignment plan for                                                                                                     | Can unify senior leaders without                                                   |

|    |                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                              |                                                                        |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | Senior Officer Alignment and Direction                           | one coherent mission; distinguish direction from micromanagement.                                                                                   | communication, priorities, reporting, and support.                                                                           | creating confusion or dependency.                                      |
| 7  | Crisis Leadership and Difficult Decisions                        | Understand how senior officers respond to conflict, instability, failure, and urgent problems; apply discipline and calm under pressure.            | Write case-study responses to three crisis-leadership scenarios.                                                             | Develops steadiness and judgment in hard moments.                      |
| 8  | Succession, Appointments, and Officer Formation                  | Explain the Commander's duty to identify, prepare, and recommend future leaders; connect senior command to succession and institutional continuity. | Create a succession and officer-development map for one full command cycle.                                                  | Grows in long-range institutional thinking.                            |
| 9  | Discipline, Correction, and Justice at the Highest Officer Level | Learn how to intervene in failing leadership, slipping standards, or structural disorder while preserving justice and fraternity.                   | Draft a corrective-action framework for addressing serious officer or command problems.                                      | Learns to correct firmly without becoming arbitrary or reactive.       |
| 10 | Stewardship of Culture, Communication, and Morale                | Apply the Rule's principles of disciplined speech, order, and communal care to senior culture-shaping leadership.                                   | Draft a command communication and morale-maintenance protocol for the Order.                                                 | Understands how culture is protected or damaged from the top.          |
| 11 | Senior Command Practicum                                         | Demonstrate the ability to assess, align, and strengthen the Order through a real or simulated senior command assignment.                           | Lead an approved senior command project and submit an after-action review.                                                   | Proves he can function as the highest officer beneath the Grandmaster. |
| 12 | Capstone Preparation and Commander's Board Review                | Integrate course learning; prepare for final portfolio, practicum review, and oral board.                                                           | Submit final portfolio: reflections, doctrine paper, alignment plan, succession map, practicum summary, and self-assessment. | Demonstrates readiness for senior command responsibility.              |

## Lesson Details

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### Lesson 1 — The Burden of Senior Command

**Focus:** The Commander must think in terms of the mission, culture, and future of the whole Order beneath the Grandmaster.

**Leadership emphasis:** A Commander is accountable not only for what is done, but for what the Order becomes under his stewardship.

**Assignment:** 1-2 page reflection on responsibility for the whole body beneath the Grandmaster.

### Lesson 2 — Senior Command in the Knights Templar

**Focus:** The historical framework for top-level Templar leadership and the way senior officers preserved coordinated action and continuity of command.

**Leadership emphasis:** Senior command exists so mission does not collapse into fragmentation, personality, or confusion.

**Assignment:** Presentation or visual summary on senior Templar command structure.

### Lesson 3 — The Offices of Marshal and Seneschal

**Focus:** The Marshal as the model of senior operational command and the Seneschal as the model of executive stewardship and coordinated governance.

**Leadership emphasis:** True senior command requires both decisive authority and disciplined executive judgment.

**Assignment:** Comparison paper between the Templar Marshal/Seneschal and your Commander rank.

### Lesson 4 — Doctrine, Mission, and Institutional Identity

**Focus:** Guarding not only activity but identity, meaning, standards, and clarity of purpose across the whole Order.

**Leadership emphasis:** If doctrine and mission are unclear, senior command becomes reactive and unstable.

**Assignment:** Institutional doctrine statement on mission, standards, and command expectations.

### Lesson 5 — Authority, Judgment, and Command Presence

**Focus:** Carrying high office with gravity, restraint, clarity, and self-command.

**Leadership emphasis:** Command presence is not theatrical force; it is disciplined steadiness others can trust.

**Assignment:** Command-presence self-assessment with mentor feedback and action plan.

## Lesson 6 — Senior Officer Alignment and Direction

**Focus:** Aligning majors, captains, and lieutenants under one coherent mission without eroding legitimate subordinate authority.

**Leadership emphasis:** The best Commander creates aligned leaders, not dependent subordinates.

**Assignment:** Senior-officer alignment plan for communication, priorities, reporting, and support.

## Lesson 7 — Crisis Leadership and Difficult Decisions

**Focus:** Thinking and acting under pressure in moments of breakdown, conflict, failed leadership, or urgent threat to mission.

**Leadership emphasis:** A Commander must bring calm, not confusion, into moments of strain.

**Assignment:** Written responses to crisis-leadership case studies.

## Lesson 8 — Succession, Appointments, and Officer Formation

**Focus:** Appointments, succession, talent identification, and the deliberate formation of future commanders and senior officers.

**Leadership emphasis:** The future strength of the Order depends on who is being formed now.

**Assignment:** Succession and officer-development map for one full command cycle.

## Lesson 9 — Discipline, Correction, and Justice at the Highest Officer Level

**Focus:** Intervening when leaders fail, standards collapse, or disorder spreads, with justice that is disciplined, proportionate, and transparent in principle.

**Leadership emphasis:** Senior correction must be firm enough to preserve order and fair enough to preserve legitimacy.

**Assignment:** Corrective-action framework for serious officer or command problems.

## Lesson 10 — Stewardship of Culture, Communication, and Morale

**Focus:** The way senior leadership shapes morale, trust, and cohesion across the Order through tone, speech, and discipline.

**Leadership emphasis:** What senior leaders permit in tone and speech becomes the climate of the whole body.

**Assignment:** Command communication and morale-maintenance protocol.

## Lesson 11 — Senior Command Practicum

**Focus:** Demonstrating the ability to assess, align, direct, and strengthen the Order through a real or realistic senior command assignment.

**Leadership emphasis:** Senior command must be demonstrated through action, judgment, and measurable strengthening of institutional life.

**Assignment:** Approved senior command project with after-action review.

## **Lesson 12 — Capstone Preparation and Commander's Board Review**

**Focus:** Integrating the whole course into one demonstration of readiness for the highest officer rank before Grandmaster.

**Leadership emphasis:** Readiness for Commander must be visible in doctrine, judgment, composure, succession thinking, and institutional stewardship.

**Assignment:** Final portfolio submission.

## Required Assignments Summary

| Assignment                                 | Purpose                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reflection on the burden of senior command | Clarify the candidate's understanding of responsibility for the whole body beneath the Grandmaster. |
| Senior Templar command presentation        | Establish historical understanding of top-level office.                                             |
| Marshal / Seneschal comparison paper       | Link the historical offices to the Commander rank.                                                  |
| Institutional doctrine statement           | Build clarity around mission, standards, and command expectations.                                  |
| Command-presence self-assessment           | Increase awareness of bearing, restraint, and visible authority.                                    |
| Senior-officer alignment plan              | Form skill in unifying the officer corps.                                                           |
| Crisis case-study paper                    | Build judgment under pressure.                                                                      |
| Succession and officer-development map     | Develop long-range continuity planning.                                                             |
| Corrective-action framework                | Form principled discipline and justice at senior level.                                             |
| Communication and morale protocol          | Build institutional clarity, cohesion, and culture protection.                                      |
| Senior command practicum and AAR           | Demonstrate applied senior leadership.                                                              |
| Final portfolio                            | Integrate all work for board review.                                                                |

## Leadership Outcomes

| Leadership Domain | Expected Outcome                                                                                                     |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Identity          | Understands the Templar senior-command model and the meaning of highest officer stewardship beneath the Grandmaster. |
| Stewardship       | Demonstrates responsibility for mission, standards, leaders, and institutional continuity across the whole Order.    |
| Discipline        | Shows composure, prudence, consistency, and mature command judgment.                                                 |

|                         |                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Obedience               | Exercises broad authority in alignment with the Order's mission, law, and higher purpose rather than personal preference. |
| Humility                | Carries high office without vanity, insecurity, or self-exaltation.                                                       |
| Speech and tone         | Communicates with clarity, restraint, and authority that preserves unity and morale.                                      |
| Care of the brotherhood | Understands how senior leadership decisions affect the welfare, trust, and health of the whole body.                      |
| Leader development      | Strengthens majors and captains while building a durable succession pipeline.                                             |
| Execution               | Can align, direct, and strengthen institutional life through a structured senior-command approach.                        |
| Promotion readiness     | Shows evidence of fitness for the highest officer office and readiness to serve immediately below the Grandmaster.        |

## Final Evaluation

| Component                      | Weight | What is assessed                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Attendance and participation   | 10%    | Presence, preparedness, engagement, and contribution to discussion.                                   |
| Written assignments            | 20%    | Historical understanding, reflection quality, doctrinal clarity, and strategic application.           |
| Command / planning assignments | 10%    | Quality of doctrine statement, alignment plan, succession thinking, and communication systems.        |
| Leader-development assignments | 10%    | Ability to strengthen senior officers and build continuity beneath the Commander.                     |
| Senior command practicum       | 20%    | Leadership judgment, alignment, communication, decision-making, and follow-through.                   |
| Senior observation             | 10%    | Bearing, humility, command presence, justice, and steadiness in highest-level officer responsibility. |
| Final portfolio                | 10%    | Integration, completeness, self-awareness, and readiness for Commander-level service.                 |
| Oral board / final review      | 10%    | Officer presence, judgment, historical grounding, and readiness for highest officer office.           |

## Sample Oral Board Questions

- Why were the Marshal and Seneschal essential to the historical Templar Order?



- What distinguishes a Commander from a Major in your Order?
- Why are the Marshal and Seneschal the right models for Commander School?
- What must a Commander protect in the Order besides outward success or activity?
- How does a Commander exercise strong authority without becoming overbearing or centralized in the wrong way?
- What principles should govern a Commander during a serious internal or external crisis?
- How do you correct failing leadership while preserving legitimacy and fraternity?
- How do you know whether the Order is actually producing future Commanders?
- Where is your greatest weakness as a future Commander, and how are you addressing it?
- Why are you ready—or not yet ready—for the highest officer position before Grandmaster?

## **Practicum Requirement**

The candidate must complete one approved senior command practicum, such as conducting an Order-wide command assessment, leading a senior officer alignment and strategy cycle, designing a succession and officer-development framework, resolving a simulated institutional crisis, or building and presenting a doctrine, communication, and morale strategy for the whole Order. The practicum should include supervisor observation and an after-action review.

## **Promotion Recommendation Standard**

A candidate should be recommended only if he completes the course requirements, demonstrates disciplined and mature conduct, shows competence in doctrine, judgment, leader development, and institutional stewardship, leads the practicum successfully, passes the oral board, and proves he can carry the mission, culture, and future of the Order as the highest officer beneath the Grandmaster.

### **Historical sources used in drafting this syllabus:**

Wikipedia — Knights Templar: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Knights\\_Templar](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Knights_Templar)

Medieval Warfare — Templars hierarchy and duties: <https://www.medievalwarfare.info/templars.htm>

Medieval Warfare — Primitive Rule of the Templars: <https://www.medievalwarfare.info/rule.htm>